Delegate Background Guide

UNESCO

UNITED NATIONS EDUCATIONAL, SCIENTIFIC AND CULTURAL ORGANIZATION

Safeguarding Cultural Identity in an Increasingly Digitalized World

BACKGROUND GUIDE

Prepared for delegates | MEA

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Letter from the Dais

Honourable Delegates,

Welcome to UNESCO. Culture lives not only in monuments and museums but also in languages, stories, music, food, rituals, crafts, and the everyday practices through which communities understand themselves. Digital platforms create extraordinary opportunities to preserve and share this heritage, but they can also concentrate visibility, commercialize cultural expression, and spread misleading or decontextualized representations.

We invite you to consider how technology can support cultural diversity without turning living cultures into static objects or letting communities lose control of their own knowledge. Explore access, representation, copyright, language preservation, digital archives, artificial intelligence, and the digital divide.

We encourage respectful debate and solutions that combine innovation with community consent, cultural rights, fair compensation, and long-term preservation.

Sincerely,
The Dais

Introduction to UNESCO

UNESCO promotes international cooperation in education, science, culture, communication, and information. In cultural policy, it supports the protection of cultural and natural heritage, the safeguarding of intangible cultural heritage, and the diversity of cultural expressions. UNESCO develops international conventions and recommendations, provides technical support, and brings states and experts together.

Digital technologies can make heritage more accessible through digitized archives, virtual museums, 3D documentation, and online language resources. UNESCO's work on culture and digital technology also stresses the need to make cultural creation and distribution fairer in the digital environment. The committee should examine both the opportunities and the risks rather than treating digitalization as automatically beneficial or harmful.

Introduction to the Agenda

Digitalization changes how culture is created, stored, circulated, and understood. Online platforms let communities share languages and traditions across borders, help diaspora communities stay connected, and allow endangered materials to be preserved in digital archives. Digital records can also help document heritage threatened by conflict, climate change, or physical deterioration.

However, access is unequal. Some communities lack reliable internet, equipment, funding, or digital skills. Algorithms may prioritize dominant languages and commercially popular content. Cultural works can be copied without consent, traditional knowledge can be misused, and AI systems may reproduce stereotypes or generate inaccurate representations. Digitized heritage can also be separated from its cultural context or treated as freely available when communities consider it restricted or sacred.

> **The central question is how to protect cultural identity while supporting open, inclusive, and responsible access. Delegates should consider community participation, language diversity, intellectual property, ethical AI, digital preservation standards, and fair remuneration for cultural workers.**

Key Terms

TERM	DEFINITION
Cultural identity	The shared practices, values, languages, histories, and expressions through which individuals and communities understand belonging.
Intangible cultural heritage	Living practices, knowledge, skills, and expressions that communities recognize as part of their heritage.

TERM	DEFINITION
Digital preservation	Maintaining digital materials so they remain accessible and usable over time.
Digital divide	Unequal access to digital technologies, connectivity, skills, and meaningful participation.
Cultural diversity	The variety of ways cultures and groups express and transmit their identities.
Intellectual property	Legal rights protecting creations such as writing, music, designs, and other original works.
Traditional knowledge	Knowledge and practices developed and maintained by communities over generations.
Algorithmic visibility	The way automated systems rank, recommend, or make content discoverable.

Key Issues

1. Language inequality

Online services and AI tools often work better in widely used languages than in languages with fewer digital resources. Community-led digitization, language datasets, and education can support linguistic diversity.

2. Ownership, consent, and sacred knowledge

Digitizing cultural material may expose restricted knowledge or allow unauthorized reuse. Communities need meaningful consent, clear access rules, and the ability to correct or withdraw sensitive material where appropriate.

3. Platform power and representation

A small number of platforms can influence which cultural works are visible. Recommendation systems may favour commercial trends, reducing the discoverability of local creators and minority cultures.

4. Copyright and fair compensation

Artists and cultural workers may struggle to control the copying, licensing, and use of their work, including its use to train AI systems. Policy must balance creator rights with education, research, access, and innovation.

5. Digital preservation and cybersecurity

Digital archives can be lost through obsolete formats, poor backups, cyberattacks, or lack of funding. Sustainable preservation requires standards, redundancy, trained staff, and community governance.

6. Misinformation and cultural appropriation

False historical claims, synthetic media, and decontextualized content can distort cultural narratives. Education, provenance information, and transparent moderation can help without suppressing legitimate cultural debate.

7. Access and digital capacity

Rural communities, small institutions, and low-income countries may lack the tools to digitize their collections. International partnerships should support infrastructure, training, and locally controlled systems.

Major Stakeholders

Member States and culture ministries

Create policy, fund preservation, and implement UNESCO instruments.

UNESCO

Convenes international cooperation and supports heritage and cultural diversity programmes.

Indigenous peoples and local communities

Define cultural priorities and decide how their heritage and knowledge should be represented.

Artists and cultural workers

Create cultural expressions and need fair compensation and protection.

Libraries, archives, and museums

Preserve, describe, digitize, and provide access to cultural collections.

Technology platforms and AI developers

Shape content visibility, data use, and digital distribution.

World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO)

Works on international intellectual-property cooperation.

Universities and civil society

Research digital culture, build capacity, and advocate for inclusion.

Past International Actions and Frameworks

1954 Hague Convention

Addresses the protection of cultural property in armed conflict.

1972 World Heritage Convention

Provides a framework for identifying and protecting cultural and natural heritage of outstanding universal value.

2003 Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage

Recognizes living heritage and the role of communities in safeguarding it.

2005 Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions
Affirms the importance of cultural diversity and national policy space for cultural expressions.

2017 Operational Guidelines for the 2005 Convention in the Digital Environment
Provide guidance for implementing the Convention amid digital transformation.

2021 UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence
Sets an international normative framework addressing human rights, diversity, and ethical AI.

UNESCO digital heritage initiatives
Projects include digital documentation, virtual museums, and tools to safeguard heritage and broaden access.

Timeline

DATE	DEVELOPMENT
1954	Hague Convention adopted to protect cultural property during armed conflict.
1972	World Heritage Convention adopted.
2003	Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage adopted.
2005	Convention on the Diversity of Cultural Expressions adopted.
2017	Operational Guidelines address the digital environment.
2019	Parties approve an open roadmap for implementing the 2005 Convention in the digital environment.
2021	UNESCO adopts its Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence.
2022	MONDIACULT Declaration emphasizes culture's role in sustainable development and digital transformation.
2024–2026	UNESCO continues its work on cultural policy in digital environments, including emerging AI-related questions.

Key Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. How can communities give meaningful consent before cultural knowledge is digitized or used to train AI?
2. What funding and training would help underrepresented languages and local archives build digital capacity?
3. How can platforms improve the discoverability of minority cultures without imposing a single definition of authenticity?

4. How should copyright and creator compensation work when cultural works are copied or used by AI systems?
5. What safeguards should apply to sacred, private, or community-restricted cultural materials?
6. How can UNESCO help states measure whether digital culture policies improve diversity and access?

Bibliography and Further Reading

Use these official and institutional sources as starting points, and check the latest documents before citing statistics or claiming that a policy is current.

UNESCO – Culture and Digital Technologies
https://www.unesco.org/en/culture-and-digital-technologies

UNESCO – 2005 Convention and the digital environment
https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/unesco-promotes-protection-cultural-goods-and-services-digital-environment

UNESCO – Intangible Cultural Heritage
https://ich.unesco.org/

UNESCO – World Heritage
https://whc.unesco.org/

UNESCO – Recommendation on the Ethics of AI
https://www.unesco.org/en/artificial-intelligence/recommendation-ethics

World Intellectual Property Organization
https://www.wipo.int/

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